# A Theoretical Analysis of the Test Error of Finite-Rank Kernel Ridge Regression

Tin Sum Cheng, Aurelien Lucchi, Ivan Dokmanić, Anastasis Kratsios, David Belius
{tinsum.cheng, aurelien.lucchi, ivan.dokmanic}@unibas.ch, kratsioa@mcmaster.ca,
david.belius@cantab.ch

University of Basel

## Contribution

1. Precise non-asymptotic upper and lower bounds for test error;
2. with ridge $\lambda$ decoupled from sample size $N$;
3. including inconsistent case (target function outside RKHS)

for under-parametrized kernel ridge regression.

## Kernel Ridge Regression

A (finite) rank-$M$ kernel $K$ is a map $K : \mathcal{X} \times \mathcal{X} \to \mathbb{R}$ defined for any $x, x' \in \mathcal{X}$ by

$$K(x, x') = \sum_{k=1}^{M} \lambda_k \psi_k(x) \psi_k(x'), \qquad (1)$$

where the positive numbers $\{\lambda_k\}_{k=1}^{M}$ are called the eigenvalues, and orthonormal functions $\psi_k \in L^2_\rho$ are called the eigenfunctions. Fix a ridge $\lambda > 0$, the regressor $f_{\mathbf{Z},\lambda}$ of the finite-rank kernel $K$ is the (unique) minimizer of

$$f_{\mathbf{Z},\lambda} \stackrel{\text{def.}}{=} \min_{f \in \mathcal{H}} \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} (f(x_i) - y_i)^2 + \lambda \|f\|^2_{\mathcal{H}}. \quad (2)$$

where $\mathcal{H} \stackrel{\text{def.}}{=} \operatorname{span}\{\lambda_1^{-1/2}\psi_1, \ldots, \lambda_M^{-1/2}\psi_M\}$ the reproducing kernel Hilbert space (RKHS) associated to $K$, and $\mathbf{Z} = (\mathbf{X}, \mathbf{y})$ a sample of size $N$.

## Test Error

- Note that $\{\psi_k\}_{k=1}^{M} \subset L^2_\rho$ are orthonormal functions;
- write target function $\tilde{f} = \sum_{k=1}^{M} \tilde{\gamma}_k \psi_k + \tilde{\gamma}_{>M} \psi_{>M}$, where
- $\tilde{\gamma}_k \in \mathbb{R}$, $\psi_{>M} \perp \psi_k$, $\forall k$;
- assume noisy sampling: $y_i = \tilde{f}(x_i) + \epsilon_i$ where
- $\mathbb{E}[\epsilon] = 0$, $\mathbb{E}[\epsilon^2] = \sigma^2 > 0$.

The finite-rank KRR (2)'s test error is

$$\mathcal{R}_{\mathbf{Z},\lambda} \stackrel{\text{def.}}{=} \mathbb{E}_{x,\epsilon}\left[(f_{\mathbf{Z},\lambda}(x) - \tilde{f}(x))^2\right]. \qquad (3)$$

Bias-Variance Decomposition:

$$\mathcal{R}_{\mathbf{Z},\lambda} = \text{bias} + \text{variance},$$

where bias measures the error when there is no noise in the label, and variance is defined to be the difference between test error and bias: variance $\stackrel{\text{def.}}{=} \mathcal{R}_{\mathbf{Z},\lambda} - \text{bias}$.

## References

[1] Mehryar Mohri, Afshin Rostamizadeh, and Ameet Talwalkar: Foundations of machine learning, 340 MIT press (2018)

[2] Arash Amini, Richard Baumgartner, and Dai Feng. Target alignment in truncated kernel ridge regression, Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems, 35:21948–21960 (2022)

[3] Francis Bach. Learning theory from first principles, https://www.di.ens.fr/~fbach/ltfp_book.pdf (2023)

## Comparison

| Assumptions / results | Mohri et al. | Amini et al. | Bach | This paper |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Include inconsistent case | ✓ | ✗ | (✓)* | ✓ |
| Bias-variance decomposition | ✗ | ✓ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Test error high probability upper bound | ✓ | ✗ | ✓ | ✓ |
| Test error high probability lower bound | ✗ | ✗ | ✗ | ✓ |
| Bounds improve with smaller ridge? | ✗ | - | ✗ | ✓ |
| Upper bound decay rate** | $\sqrt{\frac{\log N}{N}}$ | - | $\lambda + \frac{\log N}{\lambda N}$ | $(\lambda + \frac{1}{N})\sqrt{\frac{\log N}{N}}$ |

Comparison of risk-bounds for finite-rank kernel ridge regressors with previous works: Mohri et al. [1] gives a loose upper bound by Rademacher-complexity; Amini et al. [2] indeed gives an exact formula for the train error instead of the test error; Bach [3] gives an upper bound, which becomes loose when the ridge $\lambda$ is small and the model is under-parametrized. (*): The bound for the inconsistent case is implicit. (**): By decay, we mean the difference between the upper bound and its limit as $N \to \infty$.

## Main Result

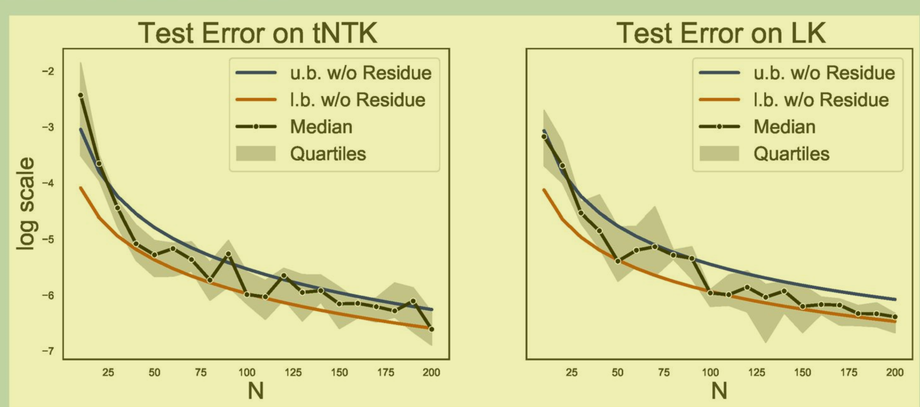
Under mild conditions on the kernel $K$, for $N$ sufficiently large, there exist some constants $C_1, C_2$ independent to $N$ and $\lambda$ such that, with a probability of at least $1 - 2/N$ w.r.t. random sampling, we have the bounds on the test error $\mathcal{R}_{\mathbf{Z},\lambda}$:

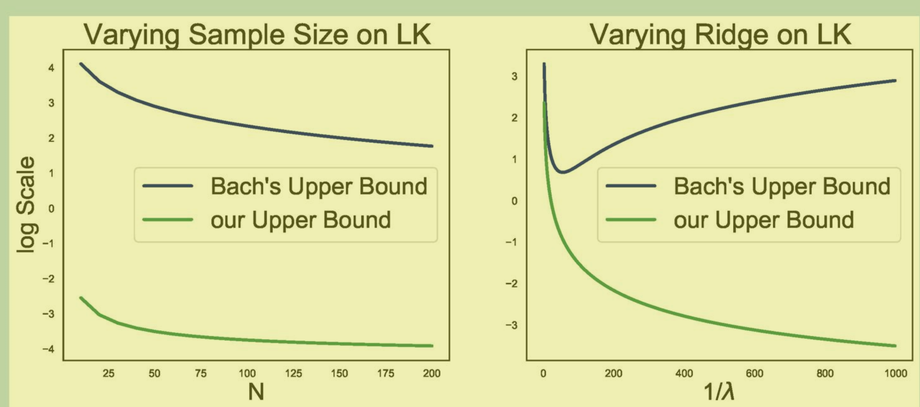
$$\mathcal{R}_{\mathbf{Z},\lambda} \le \tilde{\gamma}^2_{>M} + \lambda \|\tilde{f}_{\le M}\|^2_{\mathcal{H}} + \left(\frac{1}{4}\|\tilde{f}\|^2_{L^2_\rho} + 2\lambda \|\tilde{f}_{\le M}\|^2_{\mathcal{H}}\right)\sqrt{\frac{\log N}{N}} + C_1 \frac{\log N}{N}$$
$$+ \sigma^2 \frac{M}{N}\left(1 + \sqrt{\frac{\log N}{N}} + C_2 \frac{\log N}{N}\right);$$

$$\mathcal{R}_{\mathbf{Z},\lambda} \ge \tilde{\gamma}^2_{>M} + \frac{\lambda^2 \lambda_M}{(\lambda_k + \lambda)^2} \|\tilde{f}_{\le M}\|^2_{\mathcal{H}} - \left(\frac{1}{4}\|\tilde{f}\|^2_{L^2_\rho} + \frac{2\lambda^2}{\lambda_1 + \lambda}\|\tilde{f}_{\le M}\|^2_{\mathcal{H}}\right)\sqrt{\frac{\log N}{N}} - C_1 \frac{\log N}{N}$$
$$+ \sigma^2 \frac{M}{N}\left(1 - \sqrt{\frac{\log N}{N}} - C_2 \frac{\log N}{N}\right).$$

## Experiment

Our bounds are sharp and capture the decay of the test error in $N$: the figure below shows the simulation on two different kernels:




We also compare our upper bound with Bach [3]: